

INTRODUCTION

In 2022/23 approximately 1,586.893 children under 18 years attended the Emergency Department (ED) in the UK, of which 58,825 attended an ED in the Cambridgeshire region (Department of Health and Social Care, 2024). At least 22% (12,941) of those children will have Autism (ASD) or learning disabilities (LD) and may attend ED an average of four times a year (British Medical Journal, 2023). Research has shown that LD and Autistic children can become anxious, stressed and show unwanted behaviours because of not being correctly supported and triaged in the ED (RCEM, 2024). Patients that attend hospital on a regular basis are encouraged to have a hospital passport, this is a way of sharing health and social care concerns with hospital staff, unfortunately, very few patients presenting at ED bring their passports. Nursing staff rely on gathering information from the parent or carer at triage.

METHOD

A quantitative research method was used by asking Nursing staff to complete a poll of multiple-choice questions to gain an understanding of how they identify children presenting with Autism or learning disabilities presenting in ED.

RESULTS

The survey result showed that *staff feel a questionnaire at triage along with an easy smart phrase to record on EPIC would greatly benefit both staff and children*. A recording tool was created along with a SmartPhrase, to enable appropriate information to be recorded. To enable staff to remember what questions to ask a poster and prompt card was created with five points to record on epic (see below).

Patient has a Diagnosis of? (Tick appropriate box)

☐ Autism

☐ Learning Disability (Global delay, ADHD)

☐ Complex needs Developmental delay

☐

Communication: (Tick appropriate box)

☐ No communication concerns

☐ Patient has limited speech Prefers

☐ Makaton / sign language Prefers

☐ visual cues Patient is non-verbal

☐ Other (please describe)

☐

Does the patient have any sensory needs?

☐ Yes (please describe)

☐ No

Please avoid the following when with patient: (insert dislikes)

☐

☐

☐

This patient likes the following: (insert likes)

☐

☐

☐

Has this information been added to FYI flag?

☐ Yes

☐ No (please state why)

FIVE

QUICK POINTS TO RECORD ON EPIC

AUTISM & LEARNING DISABILITY

1

DIAGNOSIS

Recording the Childs diagnosis even if not a formal diagnosis using: .ASDTriage & .ASDFYI

2

COMMUNICATION

No communication concerns

Patient has limited speech

Prefers Makaton / sign language

Prefers visual cues

Patient is non-verbal

Other (please describe)

3

SENSORY

Yes or No, what?

Bright lights

Noisy environments

Being touched

Over stimulation

4

DISLIKES

Record anything that the patient can't tolerate such as: pain, plasters, EMLA, sats probes, touch, lots of people

5

LIKES

Record anything that the patient enjoys, that may make them less anxious such as: Characters, toys, stickers, music, TV, comforters,

PAEDIATRIC EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT



FIVE QUICK POINTS TO RECORD ON EPIC

.ASDTriage & .ASDFYI



FIVE QUICK POINTS TO RECORD ON EPIC

1

DIAGNOSIS

2

COMMUNICATION

3

SENSORY

4

DISLIKES

5

LIKES

CONCLUSION

A follow-up survey has shown that staff have a new awareness of the challenges attending ED for Autistic and Learning Disability children with their families. They have commented that they have found having information about the child's communication skills, likes and dislikes as well as sensory needs has aided them in completing observations as they are aware of any triggers for the child.

A record sheet was used to collect MRN numbers of children seen in the ED where the smartphrases have been used to record their ASD/LD status, so far 15 children have been identified. However, it is not possible to know if more children with ASD have attended the ED as there is no way of running a report and the project is reliant on staff using the SmartPhrases. So far there has been no feedback from staff to say there are any barriers to using the smartphrase. All staff asked, have agreed that the project will provide positive outcomes for these children attending ED.

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Poster created by: Jewel Inapan

Fig 1: Recording tool: EPIC SmartPhrase

Fig 2: Poster

Fig 3: Prompt card

